

Episode 144: Long Ago... 83 1995 Part 3 Shocking March (First Half) Return to Manila

This autumn, we've had a succession of obituaries for people who captivated us during our boyhood and youth and had no small influence on us, and recently even news of the accidental death of *Space Battleship Yamato's* Producer Nishizaki... What is this? I'm filled with such lonely feelings.

Looking at Mr. Nishizaki's career again, I was surprised - when that TV series *Space Battleship Yamato* that we were so enthusiastic about was being produced, he was still only in his early 40s. I see, when I lined up all night at that Shinjuku movie theatres on opening day for *Farewell Space Battleship Yamato*, the man himself I glimpsed that day was younger than I am now! Realising that gave me goosebumps.

I can't become like Mr. Nishizaki, but I want to participate with good work and dedication in as many productions as possible that all the boys and girls of today will watch. That's what I think.

Anyway.

In early March 1995, after finishing work on the theatrical *Dragon Ball Z: Fusion Reborn!! Goku and Vegeta*, I was once again heading from the pre-dawn Oizumi Studio to Narita Airport with my aluminium trunk. Another business trip to EEI-TOEI in Manila, Philippines. This time for two weeks. Last time had strong meaning as inspection & reporting, but this time I would actually work together with them and then provide various guidance.

The big difference from last time was accommodation. This time, instead of a hotel, I'd stay at a house rented for Japanese staff on long-term assignment. Near EEI-TOEI's studio, there was a section where housing for former US military personnel in the Philippines once existed, and they were renting one house in that area. The roads accessing the residential area had gates with 24-hour armed guards carrying automatic rifles, so security inside was definitely good. The residents all had a wealthy atmosphere.

Daily life in Manila: wake up in the morning, take a not-very-hot shower to wake up, walk to the studio by 10 AM. Breakfast was bought on the way to the studio - cheeseburger and cola from a hamburger stand operating on the roadside, eaten at the studio. Lunch and dinner were with studio staff at nearby restaurants. Work until around 8-9 PM then return to lodging. Such days continued. Unlike last time where someone came to pick me up at the hotel, being able to move at my own pace was very comfortable.

Actually, this time there was another person accompanying me besides myself. M-kun, an in-betweener from a certain subcontracting production company. He was to be stationed for three months as an in-between checker, and I was to take him along. M-kun and I stayed together at the Staff House (that's what we called the rented house). There was already one person staying at that Staff House: senior animation director Kino Tatsuo-san. M-kun and I were completely taken care of by Kino-san.

At that time, Toei Animation (東映動画) was putting effort into training in-betweeners at EEI-TOEI. In addition to the smoothly running finishing (仕上げ) department, they wanted to grow the in-between department to a large scale and have integrated in-between and finishing work done. In other words, the plan was to strengthen a system where rough animation sent to the Manila studio would properly return to Tokyo as cels. While colouring work could stably handle quite a volume, in-betweening hadn't reached that level yet, and there were often temporary breaks in colouring while waiting for in-betweening to finish. So training in-betweeners and stabilising quality and quantity was urgent. Furthermore, they were also training background staff at the Manila studio. And even further, they were preparing one camera stand. They aimed to construct a system where even photography would be done in Manila - send rough animation and get film back.

So Kino-san was there for that in-betweener training. Actually, Kino-san was fluent in English, so communication with local staff had absolutely no barriers. Particularly for teaching in-betweening nuances, language is important after all. It was just wonderful!

And at the same time, I was envious. The "students" trying to learn in-betweening seemed lively, full of desire to study! to learn! Among those students, some had difficulty progressing due to natural "aptitude" differences, but their earnest attitude was admirable.

On the other hand, what about our finishing? Looking around, many people were certainly working seriously, but there were still several staff with a "this kind of thing, you know, just do it roughly like this" attitude. Being there longer and watching, unlike last time, such points gradually became visible. But those types had strange confidence and pride, and no matter how much I warned them and tried to get them to improve, it was completely useless. Tracing and colouring should be special skills, but conversely, they're also skills "anyone can do to some extent." Those doing it understand this, and the motivation vectors underlying "drawing" and "painting" seem quite different.

Even so, what bound together such finishing in a sense was the "inspection" team. They (overwhelmingly female) were members pulled up from tracing and colouring, and not only did finishing inspection after colouring, but also provided technical guidance to tracing and colouring staff through completion checks, took care of consistency for inadequate parts of colour direction we put in from Tokyo, or directly inquired with Tokyo. Moreover, inspection and retake processing was a race against time until flights to Tokyo departed. Their work ethic was truly admirable.

Having received lots of courage and lots of harsh opinions about colour direction improvements from those women, I headed home (bitter laugh).

And then, several days later. I was in Narita Airport's departure lobby again. This time, heading to Seoul, Korea!

(10.11.09)